Code review skills: built-in vs own

/code-review (built into Claude Code 2.1.302, default level "high") compared with **/reviewBranch** (own skill). 2 repositories, 4 branches, 2 runs per skill and branch = 16 reviews. Model Opus 5.5. 17–18 Oct 2026.

> **Recommendation: use both skills. Use /reviewBranch on every branch. Add /code-review on safety-relevant code and before each release.**
> /reviewBranch gives a short list that you can trust, but it misses important bugs. /code-review finds the important bugs, but more than half of its list is noise. The two skills cost the same.

91% · **44%**	**0 / 4** · **4 / 4**	**1 / 2** · **2 / 2**	**$0.86** · **$0.88**
Precision: real findings ÷ all reported findings	Runs that found the safety-gate bug (a document can skip human review)	Runs that found the high-severity bug (errors no longer shown)	Median cost per review (a tie). About 2–3 minutes each.

WHAT WE FOUND

1. **/reviewBranch is precise.** 10 of its 11 findings are real. It reported no false finding. When it finds a bug, its severity is the same as the owner's.
2. **/reviewBranch misses bugs.** It did not find the safety-gate bug in 4 of 4 runs. In 3 runs it examined that code and said it was correct. In 3 of 4 runs on the HR tool, it said "mergeable" while a known bug was present.
3. **/code-review finds more.** It found every known bug that either skill found, in every run. It reported 31 real findings. /reviewBranch reported 10.
4. **/code-review is noisy.** 35 of its 71 findings are weak, and 5 are false. At the default level, it does not check its findings. A person must sort the list.
5. **Cost is not a reason to choose.** Each review costs $0.50–$1.79. The difference between the skills is in the noise.

WHAT TO DO

Now

- Run **/reviewBranch** on every branch. Fix what it reports.
- On safety-relevant code (HR tool, file handling, approvals) and before each release, also run **/code-review**. Sort its list before you act. Expect about half to be noise.
- Do not trust a "mergeable" verdict alone on safety-relevant code.

Next

- Add the **removed-behaviour check** from /code-review to /reviewBranch: for each check that the branch removes or bypasses, name what it protected and find where the new code protects it again. This check found the safety-gate bug.
- Measure the other levels of /code-review ("low" to "max", and "ultra"). We do not know their noise yet.

> **Decision for the owner.** The rule that we fixed before the test selects **/reviewBranch**, because /code-review is below the 50% precision limit. The rule does not count missed bugs. Do you want the next round to include "finds the known high-impact bugs" as a criterion?

EVIDENCE 1 — MEASURED RESULT PER BRANCH

Branch	Skill	Cost USD	Tokens	Turns	Time s	Reported	Real	Weak	False
Game: media script	**reviewBranch**	0.60–0.61	383–498 k	9–11	101–109	1–3	1–2	0–1	0
15 files	**code-review**	0.50–0.51	334–340 k	8	109–112	10	5–6	4–5	0
Game: factions	**reviewBranch**	0.81–0.84	878 k–1.0 M	18–20	113–166	2	2	0	0
21 files	**code-review**	0.64	691–768 k	13–16	123–141	9	5–6	3–4	0
HR tool: safety core	**reviewBranch**	0.88–0.92	980 k–1.0 M	15–16	129–143	0	0	0	0
18 files	**code-review**	1.12–1.32	2.0–2.5 M	27–32	174–196	7–8	1	5	1–2
HR tool: 6 commits	**reviewBranch**	1.78–1.79	2.9 M	30–31	174–238	1–2	1–2	0	0
61 files	**code-review**	1.32–1.42	2.2–2.5 M	25–26	204–271	8–10	3–4	4–5	0–2
All 16 reviews		**8.23 · 7.46**		**17 · 20.5**	**136 · 158**	**11 · 71**	**10 · 31**	**1 · 35**	**0 · 5**

Ranges show the two runs. The totals row shows **reviewBranch** · **code-review**: sums for cost and counts, medians for turns and time. “Real” = a confirmed defect. “Weak” = true, but trivial or only possible in theory. “False” = wrong. We checked each of the 82 findings in the code. A separate agent checked the HR findings, and we checked its decisions by sample. The cost of /reviewBranch includes a higher cache price in the main session. At equal cache prices, each skill is cheaper on 2 of the 4 branches.

EVIDENCE 2 — KNOWN BUGS (THE OWNER FIXED THEM LATER)

Bug in the HR tool (owner severity)	reviewBranch	code-review
After the first error dialog closes, the program shows no more errors (high)	1 of 2 runs	2 of 2, rank 1
The OCR step still fails for user names with special characters on Windows (medium)	2 of 2	2 of 2
A naming rule drops a required field, so a document can skip human review (low, safety gate)	**0 of 4**	**4 of 4**
Four other low items	0	0

Game repository: the only medium bug (a removed team can change the alliances) was found in all 4 runs, 2 per skill.

EVIDENCE 3 — HOW THE SKILLS ARE DIFFERENT

Property	/reviewBranch	/code-review (level “high”)
Aim	Precision: check every finding, report no guesses.	Recall: “err on the side of surfacing”.
Method	One free pass. It follows the data flow.	8 fixed checks, for example removed behaviour, callers, duplicate code, project rules.
Check of findings	**Yes. It runs tests and tools.**	**No (“dedup only, no verify”).**
Result	**Severity, rank and a merge verdict.**	**A list without severity or verdict.**
Base branch	**Finds main, master or develop.**	**Can miss commits on “master” repositories.**
Options	**One mode.**	**5 levels, cloud review, auto-fix, PR comments.**
Control	**You own the text.**	**It changes with each Claude Code release.**

Limits: two repositories, four branches, two runs per cell. The known-bug list comes from a later review by the owner, which also used AI, so it is not fully independent. We tested only the default level of /code-review. The usage limit stopped two HR runs; we ran them again 5 hours later. The HR tool is internal code; only totals appear here. Method, decision rule (fixed before the test), data and transcripts: **codingWithGPT/20261017_comparisonReviewSkills**. Text style: ASD-STE100 Simplified Technical English, about 80% adherence.